

Vista Woes

TTO JUDGE BY the various sources that attempt to assess Linux market share on the desktop, there has been a surge in recent months. To judge by anecdotal evidence, the reason for that surge is pretty clear — Windows Vista. As it becomes increasingly difficult to buy a new machine with Windows XP — still not impossible — users are forced to decide if they wish to put up with the problems associated with Vista. There is plenty of evidence to suggest that many people are becoming Vista refugees and turning to Linux.

All new operating systems have teething problems, and users often react negatively to change, but there is more to the problems faced by Vista, and the most compelling evidence of this is the behaviour of Microsoft. Take the update schedule for Vista and XP. Microsoft recently committed to continue to provide security updates for XP until at least 2014 — and this is just a little longer than the company is allowing for Vista Ultimate. Now things might well change, but if they do not, this means that you will still get such support for XP after it has ceased for Vista. No doubt things will change, but what sort of message does this give out about these two operating systems?

There is no doubt that XP is by far the more popular of the two, and the problems with Vista lie in its design and implementation. So, if they were your products that you were trying to sell to the world, what would you do? What would be the logical approach? Spend lots of money updating the popular XP, enabling it to handle more memory and modern hardware? Perhaps you would throw potentially more money at Vista development and try to address all the issues that frustrate users?

To me, these seem the only sensible approach, but Microsoft instead throws huge amounts of money — \$300 million — into marketing; clearly, we poor users have not understood the message. All those problems were because I was simply stupid. Maybe you have seen the Microsoft advert that depicts a ship about to sail off the edge of the world as it was conceived a few hundred years ago? It states: “At one point, everyone thought the Earth was flat. Get the facts about Windows Vista.”

So, if you do not like Vista, the message seems to be that you have the intelligence and understanding of a flat-earthier rather than a globularist



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(yes, that really is the term by which flat-earthers refer to the rest of us). In what business school is it taught that marketing consists in insulting the intelligence of your potential customers? This is quite bizarre, and is unusual even for Microsoft, which has always been keen on getting the “right” message across.

Also have a look at the TV advert entitled “Bill Gates and Jerry Seinfeld — Shoe Circus Commercial”. You’ll easily find it on the Web. Just how on Earth this is expected to improve the image of Vista, let alone the code base — which is what really matters — is beyond me.

If Microsoft wants to stop the flood of Vista refugees over the open source border, this is certainly not the way to go about it.

Now where did I put those Ubuntu disks?

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